

Boston Dynamics — People Ops Phone Screen Prep

Sep 28, 2026 · @Alejandro

Phone screen with People Ops (Kacey Boston) on Sep 26, 2026, for the Atlas Research Engineer, SLAM & Spatial AI role.

What this screen actually is

A People Ops screen is not a technical deep-dive. Kacey is checking fit, motivation, and logistics — not grilling on bundle adjustment. Aim for a 2-3 sentence version of each answer, then stop and let her steer.

- Have a 60-second story ready: PhD at DLR → Research Scientist at QUT → why Atlas now.
- Expect: background walkthrough, why this role, why now, availability, comp range, visa/relocation.
- Keep technical language light; save depth for the engineering interviews later in the loop.

Your fit, in plain language

Say this without the acronyms first, then let follow-up questions pull the detail out:

“I build the vision systems that let a robot know exactly where it is and what it’s touching, down to the millimeter. I’ve done that for drones on DLR’s Mars-analogue missions, for underwater robots on coral reefs, and now I lead a research team at QUT doing it for general-purpose SLAM. Atlas is the same core problem — knowing where a body and its hands are in space — on the best hardware in the world for testing that.”

- Real-time tracking → led AllFeature-VSLAM (real-time monocular SLAM).
- 3D reconstruction → built a full Gaussian Splatting reconstruction pipeline (Bommie Toolkit).
- Rigor under real sensors → years of work on camera calibration, drift, and bundle adjustment on physical rigs, not just simulation.
- Track record → 400+ citations, h-index 9, a CVPR oral, and papers across ICRA/IROS/RA-L/RSS/BMVC.
- Team-ready → currently supervises 4 PhD students and lectures a SLAM course at QUT.

Why leave QUT now

- Ready to push my technical and professional skills against a much stronger engineering bench, on production-grade code rather than small-academic-team research code.
- In academia you don’t see how research actually gets deployed — which shortcuts hold up and which don’t. That judgment only comes from being embedded in a team shipping real systems.
- Want to work at the frontier of engineering, collaboration, and how research gets scoped and prioritized at scale — beyond what I can push myself to alone.
- Keep this upbeat and forward-looking, not a complaint about QUT.

Why Boston Dynamics / Atlas

- Atlas is some of the best hardware in the world for spatial perception research — a step up from a DLR research multicopter, GoPro footage, and self-built underwater rigs.
- Fast iteration and real-world validation at scale, instead of staying confined to papers and benchmarks.
- If asked about the humanoid/VLA gap: be upfront my work has been on aerial, underwater, and ground robots, not humanoids — then bridge it. The core problem is the same: state estimation and 3D structure feeding a downstream system. At DLR that was navigation; here it’s conditioning learned policies. The geometry doesn’t change with the embodiment.
- If asked about production-scale code: point to VSLAM-LAB — a unified, reproducible, multi-baseline framework, not one-off research code — as evidence of engineering discipline beyond academia.

Logistics to have ready

People Ops screens usually probe these directly — have a clear, confident answer rather than working it out live:

- **Visa/relocation:** currently in Brisbane, Australia; open to relocating to the US, will need visa sponsorship — say so plainly if asked.

- **Timeline:** when could you realistically start, given QUT notice period and any teaching/supervision commitments.
- **Comp expectations:** have a rough range in mind going in, but it's fine to defer specifics ("happy to discuss once we're further along") if not ready to commit to a number.
- **Availability for further interviews:** be ready to name a few dates/windows that work.

Questions to ask her

- What does the timeline look like from here — through the remaining interview stages, an offer, visa sponsorship, and relocation, to a realistic start date?
- What does a typical contract look like for this role — full-time vs. fixed-term, standard length if fixed-term, and how equity/bonus typically works?
- What does the rest of the interview loop involve, so I can prepare appropriately for each stage?

Notes from the call

- Alberto Rodriguez
- applied research
- rfl team
- dexterous manipulation
- vla research team – role